

SIPRA LARA



Tactical Retreat

LUCKNOW Not wanting to be branded as the bad 'M', Chief Minister Mayawati made a hasty turnaround over stalling the rail coach factory in Sonia Gandhi's constituency Rae Bareilly. Her decision to impose Section 144 to thwart Sonia's designs of performing a 'bhoomi

pujan' at the proposed factory venue on October 14 threatened to push Mayawati into the league of Mamata Banerjee. The Trinamool Congress chief's tantrums led to the departure of the Tata's Nano facility at Singur in West Bengal.

Accused of trying to

DAMAGE CONTROL: Mayawati

stifle development in her state, Mayawati went into damage control mode: she ordered an inquiry into the rail coach factory issue. She then ordered the restoration of land to the railways for setting the coach factory, signalling that she is pro-development.

Mayawati may have blinked this time, but on the side she is preparing a dossier on the mother-son duo of Sonia and Rahul Gandhi—what they have done for the state in the past five years. She intends telling the electorate that for the Gandhi duo, Uttar Pradesh means only Rae Bareilly and Amethi. Mayawati may have lost the battle, but she is bent on intensifying the war.

by Subhash Mishra

Not by the Numbers

BHUBANESHWAR Chief Minister Naveen Patnaik may claim that Orissa has emerged as an island of harmony with just two incidents of communal violence in the past eight-and-a-half months. The Centre, however, doesn't agree. It has highlighted that in the first nine months of Patnaik's tenure, there were 158 incidents of communal violence. This includes the barbaric anti-church attacks in and around Kandhamal that claimed 41 lives. This puts Orissa at the top of the states bearing the brunt of com-



COMMUNAL FURY: A vandalised church in Orissa

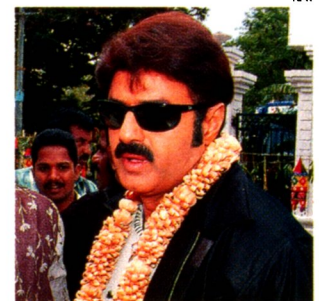
munal unrest. In contrast, between 2000 and 2007, there were 151 cases of communal violence with 22 dead in Orissa. Maoist guerrillas are also making their presence felt in 20 of its 30 districts; 72 policemen were killed by Maoists in the past year.

BJP-ruled Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh figure at number two and three on the communal riots list with Jharkhand and Chhattisgarh clocking fewer incidents of Maoist violence than Patnaik's "peaceful" state.

by Farzand Ahmed

Family Opera

HYDERABAD The TDP is getting jittery with Telugu actor Chiranjeevi's arrival on the political stage in Andhra Pradesh. To counter the fledgling Praja Rajyam Party founder president, the TDP is fielding party founder N.T. Rama Rao's fifth son Nandamuri Balakrishna, also an actor. At 48, he has starred in 89 films and will make his political debut in Guntur on November 5. TDP chief N. Chandrababu Naidu, who unseated his father-in-law Rama Rao to



STAR POWER: Balakrishna

become chief minister, has welcomed this. Naidu lacks a filmstar's charisma and fan following. He has also lost his earlier support as the harbinger of information technology in the state.

Supporters argue that Balakrishna should be projected as a chief ministerial candidate to check the Chiranjeevi juggernaut. For Naidu, this also allows him keep options open to play kingmaker on the national scene by contesting for a Lok Sabha seat. Further, he can rely on Balakrishna more than anyone else—the star's elder daughter Brahmani is married to Naidu's only son, Lokesh. As they say, it's all in the family.

by Amarnath K. Menon